RENDEZ-VOUS WITH ROCCO IACOPINI

Back in 1977, Rocco Iacopini, born in Siena in 1947, founded the tea house "Mago Merlino" in the heart of Florence. This astonishing world was born out of Rocco's passion for the practice of tea drinking, palmistry, tarot cards, and Morocco. Arranging the interior design of the house throughout the years, Rocco merged diverse cultures in the fantasy of arabesques, in the magic of the vivid colors and fabrics, in the rhythms of Asian music. Besides, you can find there chess, backgammon, dominoes, a loud piano, a guitar, and some drums. Today, drinking a flavourful Pu-Ehr with the founder and being filled with the spirit of this ritual, we are fortunate to have a small conversation with Rocco digging deeper into his ethereal world and exploring his personality.

AE: What is the ideology you believe in?

RI: What guides me throughout life has changed over time. When I was 20-30 years old I felt like the king of life and was not reflecting so much. I started to reflect very late. After the school of life, after obtaining knowledge and wisdom, I try to give the best of me to life, to express my personality by respecting others. But my main philosophy is madness. Creative and artistic madness. It means not taking things seriously, being conducted by life itself. Madness is divine, as I see it. It is a spiritual aspect. I am amazed by the wonders and ephemerality of life.

AE: The other day, during our friendly conversation at the tea table, you told me that "There is a lack of madness in this world". Can you elaborate on your opinion regarding this latest declaration?

RI: I like colors, flavors, and beautiful perfumes of nature. The point is in the world in which we exist today. The problem of globalization - when this grey blanket covers the traditions. We need more anecdotes, humanity, and compassion in our lives. We should not be rational and take life seriously.

AE: How has your experience in Morocco influenced the person you are now in comparison with previous you when you still had not explored this outstanding country?

RI: It was my wife who brought me to Morocco for the first time and from the very first day there I remained amazed by the different life, by the fact that people maintained traditions that they keep on be dedicated to, by the humanity of persons. Also, the spiritual sense in Marocco is very interesting because they refer to God every moment of their lives. As they see it, a human being is as small as big at the same time. The sense of religion that transmits to the communal life, and the strength of spirituality, compassion and brotherhood that we do not have anymore fascinated me.

AE: The Moroccan interior style of "Mago Merlino Tea House" took me out of Italy as soon as I entered inside. Since, in the past centuries, the formation of Moroccan culture was influenced by different folks and religions - African, Muslim, Arab, and Berber people, - Moroccan antiques and ex-

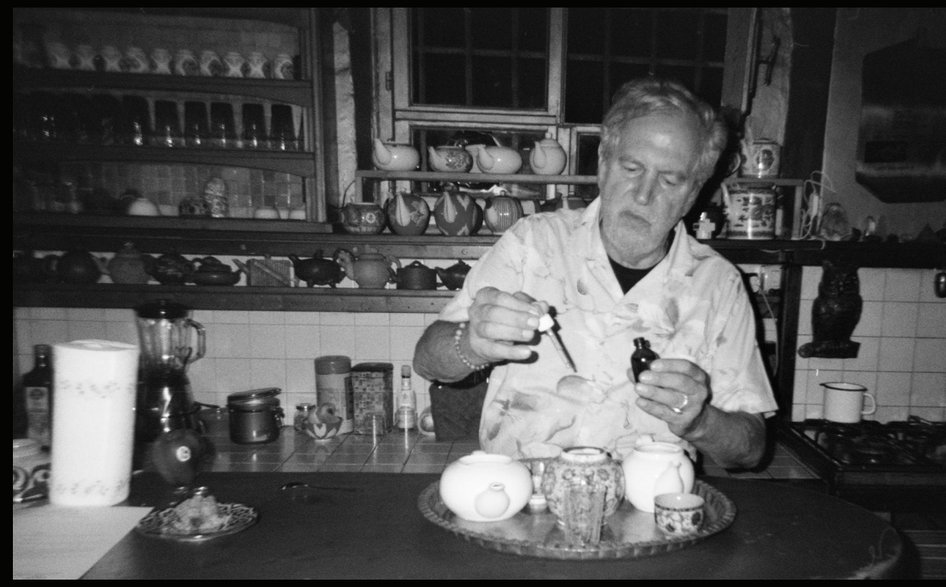


Photo by Aleksandra Eremashvili

traordinary objects that you store in your house are a rich oriental treasury in the heart of Florence. Can you tell us about the most meaningful relics that you brought from Morocco?

RI: Two big curtains. There are 22 doors embroidered on them, 11 on each. This gold circle-shaped ornament above represents the believer who is praying because if you watch attentively you may notice that these ornaments have silhouettes of arms. Nowadays the price of one curtain can reach 10.000 Eur, did you know? Because they are handcrafted, have more than 55 years and don't exist anymore.

AE: What is the difference in approach to dress of Moroccans in comparison with Europeans?

RI: Moroccans dress traditionally. Djellaba is a national long male costume. Meanwhile, the dress called Kaftan is the same thing but for women. You can find many stores on the streets of Marocco where they sell exclusively traditional dresses. Nevertheless, we are in 2024 people there still maintain the extremely high value of tradition and family. Meanwhile, Moroccan official costume, as I told you before, is a long dress with a hood and wide pants in addition to leather slippers with a sharp toes, the official costume everywhere in the rest of the world is a tie with a shirt, jacket and pants.

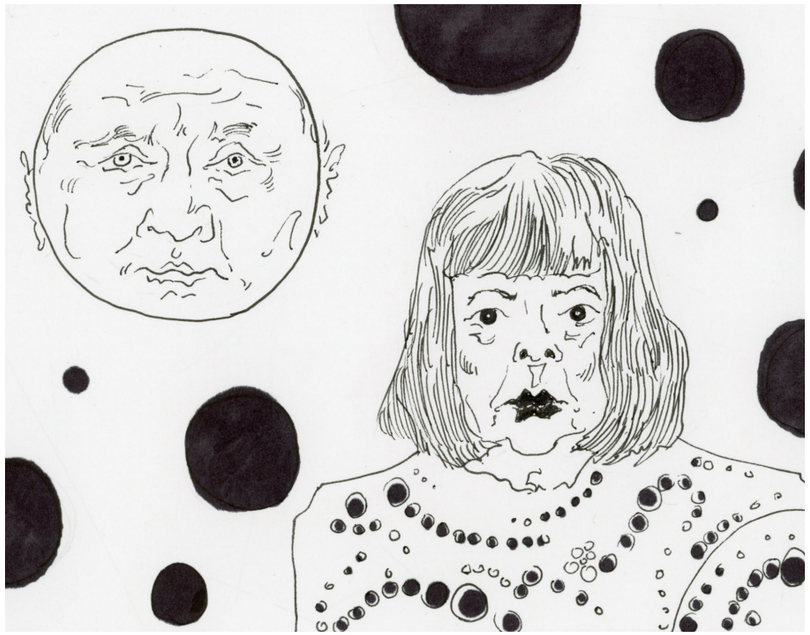
AE: You have been living in Florence since your twentieth, which means, for more or less 60 years already. From your point of view, how the attitude toward the fashion of Florentines has been changing throughout the years?

RI: What has been changing is how Florentines dress their bodies as well as how they dress their souls. Because we are strongly influenced by globalization. By cinema, music, social media, trends, etc. It has an impact on the subconscious of people and subsequently on the way how they express themselves.

IMPOSSIBLE RENDEZ - VOUS N O . 2

Yayoi Kusama & Vladimir Putin

In a whimsical alternate dimension where the boundaries of time and space were fluid, Yayoi Kusama and Vladimir Putin found themselves seated on opposite ends of a peculiar polka-dotted table in a room that seemed to stretch into infinity.



Drawing by Mobina Khalili